Message from Premier Chou en Lai to President Nixon

May 29, 1971

Premier Chou En Lai sincerely thanks His Excellency President Yahya Khan for most rapidly transmitting the three messages from President Nixon.

Premier Chou En Lai has seriously studied President Nixon's messages of April 29, May 17th and May 22nd 1971, and has reported with much pleasure to Chairman Mao Tse Tung that President Nixon is prepared to accept his suggestion to visit PeKing for direct conversations with the Leaders of the Peoples Republic of China. Chairman Mao Tse Tung has indicated that he welcomes President Nixon's visit and looks forward to that occasion when he may have direct conversations with His Excellency the President, in which each side would be free to raise the principal issue of concern to it. It goes without saying that the first question to be settled is the crucial issue between China and the United States which is the question of the concrete way of the withdrawal of all the US Armed forces from Taiwan and Taiwan Straits Area.

Premier Chou En Lai welcomes Dr Kissinger to China as the US representative who will come in advance for a preliminary secret meeting with high level Chinese officials to prepare and make necessary arrangements for President Nixon's visit to PeKing.

Premier Chou En Lai suggests that it would be preferable for Dr Kissinger to set a date between June 15 and 20th for his arrival in China, that PeKing may be the location and that he may fly direct from Islamabad to a Chinese PeKing Airport not open to the Public. As for the flight, he may take a Pakistan Boeing aircraft or a Chinese special plane can be sent to fly him to and from

China, if needed. The talks plus the flights on both ways will probably take three or four days. If there is the desire to use his own telecommunication equipment on a temporary basis during his stay in Peking, he may do so.

As it is difficult to keep Dr Kissinger's trip strictly secret, he may well consider coming for the meeting in an open capacity. If secrecy is still desired, the Govt of the Peoples Republic of China will, on its part, guarantee the strict maintenance of secrecy. When the talks have yielded results, the two Sides may agree to a public announcement to be made after the meeting, if it is so desired.

As for other details, they may be discussed and arranged through President Yahya Khan directly with the Chinese Ambassador.

Premier Chou En Lai warmly looks forward to the meeting with Dr Kissinger in Peking in the near future."

Message Ends.

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I notice from the above message that the Premier has given an alternative for an open meeting between himself and Dr Kissinger. Knowing Dr Kissinger's desire to maintain strict secrecy which fact I have been impressing upon Premier Chou En Lai, the above message is indicative of the Premier's acceptance of the secret meeting for which he has given guarantee. The rest will depend upon US and Pakistan maintaining secrecy.

As regards arrangements on our part, I have discussed with the Chinese Ambassador and propose as follows:

a. Dr Kissinger arrives on a D Day
b. After a 24 hours stop in Islamabad and a meal with me, he will ostensibly make a trip to a place not open to public in the Northern region. In actual fact, a Pakistani Boeing will carry him along the Northern route direct to Peking from Islamabad. The time of flight will be approximately seven hours. On completion of the mission, Dr Kissinger will return to Islamabad to resume his onward journey.

If Dr Kissinger would find it helpful, I am considering sending a high level Pakistani with him to Peking.